

or otherwise, it is necessary to protect your progress and healing from those who would try – intentionally or not – to sabotage it.

I grew up afraid of boundaries, because I didn't want to be cold or closed off. My childhood heroine, the famously unboundaried and free-spirited Anne Shirley from *Anne of Green Gables*, would never put up walls between herself and anyone but Gilbert Blythe – and even that didn't last for ever. I thought that to be boundaried was to be selfish, and the example set by my (wonderful) mother was that you give away as much of yourself as you possibly can in the hope of making others happy. But what I've realized since is that it doesn't work. It leaves you empty and anxious, and the needs of others are still just as vast and insatiable. Money is one of many resources that we need to lead a good life, and I've found that it is almost always acutely affected by any boundary issues that we might have. It's normal to worry about putting new boundaries in place, especially when it comes to money – when your relationships mean a lot to you, it's natural to worry about anything that poses a potential risk to the closeness you have with those you care about. Nobody wants to be perceived as 'tight' or 'mean', even though those labels will inevitably mean different things to different people, and preserving enough of our resources to achieve a sense of happiness and wellbeing for ourselves should never be anything to be ashamed of.

It's worth noting that having healthy boundaries isn't only about what we give away – it's about what we take on. We